

The entry point for luxury cars has moved up. For Mercedes-Benz, the share of top-end cars has risen from 15% to 25%

Longitude 77 are changing that for a consumer "who increasingly judges quality on its own merit, rather than its country of origin". Amrut, Paul John, Rampur and Indri have built followings at home and abroad. In 2025, Indian malts reached about 5,00,000 cases, up around 22%, according to data from the Confederation of Indian Alcoholic Beverage Companies, compared with roughly 3,50,000 cases of imported single malts.

THE NEW BUYER

In *Hindi Medium*, the 2017 Bollywood comedy, Irrfan Khan plays Raj Batra, a Delhi shopkeeper with plenty of money but limited social standing. To fit in, he dresses himself and his wife in expensive brands. Hundekari uses this to describe the most important buyer.

"These are owners of small and medium businesses, a group that rarely features in brand presentations," says Hundekari. "A trader in Mumbai's Crawford Market, a cotton dealer or the owner of a small factory who may be worth ₹100 crore." They use luxury brands to buy social status. "It's not South Bombay or South Delhi alone that have the taste for brands, craftsmanship, or experiences," says Karan Bhangay, who founded Indulge, a members-only luxury concierge, and has worked with wealthy clients for nearly 15 years. "I have worked with clients from places like Salem, Chandigarh, and beyond, who are often misread as they are judged for wealth by metro markers."

They don't always speak English, dress differently, and have different choices than metro HNIs. "You can meet people who are worth a few thousand crores and drive a Baleno," says Bhangay.

The second group is start-up entrepreneurs